

The Farmer and the Rats

A story in the style of a folk tale

Chapter 1: Ramu the Farmer and His Field

In a small village called Rampur lived a farmer named Ramu. Ramu was very hardworking. Every morning he set out for his fields, and from dawn till dusk he ploughed, sowed seeds, and watered his crops. He owned five bighas of land, on which he grew wheat, millet, and maize.

Ramu's wife, Sita, was just as hardworking. She kept the house, raised chickens, and carefully stored the grain brought in from the fields in their granary. They had two children — Mohan and Gita — who were still young but were learning to help their parents in the fields.

The people of the village often held up Ramu's diligence as an example. "If every farmer worked like Ramu, even famine would give up," old Chaudhary would say.

But that year, something strange began to happen. The grain in Ramu's granary started disappearing. At first he thought there must be some mistake in his counting, but when the grain kept vanishing for three or four days in a row, he grew suspicious.

One night, by the dim light of an oil lamp, Ramu noticed something moving in a corner of the granary. He crept closer quietly and saw — not one, but several rats scurrying about. They had gnawed holes in the sacks of grain and were stealing kernel after kernel.

"So that's what's going on," Ramu said, striking his forehead. "These little thieves have been eating up all my grain."

Chapter 2: The Kingdom of the Rats

Beneath the granary, under the earth, lived a whole colony of rats. Its chief was Chhotu, a clever and experienced rat. Chhotu was not old, but his wisdom was such that all the rats accepted him as their leader.

Chhotu had three close companions — Motu, who loved eating more than anything; Cheeku, who was the fastest runner; and Budhiya, an old female rat known for her wisdom.

"Chief Chhotu," Motu said one day, "there's so much grain in that farmer's granary that we could eat for seven generations. Why should we be afraid?"

Chhotu shook his head gravely. "Motu, greed is a terrible curse. We should take only as much as we need. If the farmer finds out we're eating all his grain, he'll come after us."

Budhiya agreed as well. "Chhotu is right. Have you not heard the story of our ancestors — when the rats ate up an entire farmer's grain, he brought in cats, and the whole colony was destroyed?"

But Motu and some of the younger rats laughed off Budhiya's words. "That's just an old woman's tale. Right now is the time to enjoy ourselves."

Gradually, the greedy voices like Motu's began to dominate, and every night the colony raided the granary.

Chapter 3: Ramu's Plan

After much thought, Ramu devised a plan. He had the village blacksmith make iron traps, baited them with peanuts, and set them at various spots around the granary.

The next morning, when he went in, he found three rats caught in the traps. One of them was Cheeku.

Ramu picked up the trap to carry Cheeku away, but just then his daughter Gita arrived.

"Papa, wait!" Gita said. "Don't hurt it. Look how frightened it is."

Ramu paused. His daughter had always had a tender heart. "Dear, these rats eat up all our grain. If we don't stop them, we'll starve."

Gita looked at the trembling Cheeku in the trap and said, "Papa, maybe they get hungry too. Can't we talk to them and find some other way?"

Ramu laughed. "Child, does anyone ever talk to rats?"

But that night, sleep would not come to Ramu. Gita's words kept echoing in his mind.

Chapter 4: Chhotu's Worry

Mourning spread through the colony. Cheeku and two other companions had been captured. Chhotu called an urgent meeting at once.

"See," said Chhotu, "I told you greed would be our downfall. Now the farmer has set traps. We must change our ways."

Motu spoke up, ashamed. "Chief, what do we do now? What if that farmer brings in cats?"

Budhiya stepped forward. "There is one way. Instead of fighting the farmer, we should make peace with him. We can help him — in return, he can leave us a little grain."

"Rats and a farmer, friends?" one of the rats laughed. "That's impossible!"

But Chhotu found sense in Budhiya's words. "We are rats — that doesn't mean all we know how to do is steal. We know everything beneath the earth — where water seeps, where termites nest, where the snake's burrow is. Perhaps we can be of use to the farmer."

Chapter 5: The First Message

Chhotu devised an unusual plan. At the edge of Ramu's field, along the path he walked every morning, the rats arranged small pebbles into a marker — an arrow pointing toward a particular spot.

The next morning Ramu saw the marker and was startled. "Who made this?" he wondered. Curious, he began walking in the direction the arrow pointed.

The marker led him to a corner of the field where water was seeping up from underground — a spot where, while digging their burrows, the rats had discovered an old underground spring.

Ramu realized that if he dug a well here, he would have water even in the dry season. He immediately called the villagers together to dig a well, and sure enough, sweet water gushed forth.

"Strange," Ramu told Sita. "I don't know who made that marker, but it has helped us greatly."

Gita smiled and said, "Papa, maybe it was one of those rats."

Ramu laughed, but a small seed of doubt had been planted in his mind.

Chapter 6: The Beginning of Trust

A few days later, another incident occurred. A snake lived along the edge of Ramu's field and sometimes harmed the chickens. One night, the rats cleverly lured the snake out of its burrow to a spot where Ramu's dog could easily spot it. The dog's barking woke Ramu, and he managed to drive the snake far from the field.

Ramu now began to believe that some unseen helper was protecting his farm. He removed the traps from the granary and instead began leaving a little grain aside each night in one corner — as if thanking someone.

Chhotu and his companions were delighted to see this. "You see," Chhotu told Budhiya, "what greed could never get us, trust has brought."

Motu, too, admitted his mistake. "Chief, forgive me. I understand now — we should take only what we need, and in return, learn to give something back."

Chapter 7: The Drought Crisis

But the happiness did not last long. That year, very little rain fell. Even the well's water began to dwindle. The crops started to wither. Deep lines of worry etched themselves across Ramu's face.

"If it doesn't rain," Ramu told Sita, "we'll go hungry this year. What will become of Mohan and Gita?"

In the colony too, there was worry. If the farmer's crop failed, the rats would have nothing to eat either.

Budhiya said, "Chhotu, our ancestors told of an old stepwell at the foot of the hill that never runs dry. But the path to it is buried under wild bushes and stones — no human knows of it."

Chhotu decided that this time, they would help Ramu directly, whatever the risk.

Chapter 8: The Path to the Stepwell

Working through the night, the rats built a long trail — a clear path of packed earth and pebbles leading from the field to the foot of the hill. At the end of the trail, they left the

leaf-covered mouth of the old stepwell partly uncovered, so Ramu could spot it.

The next morning, when Mohan went toward the fields, he saw the unusual path and ran to fetch his father.

Ramu and some villagers followed the trail to the foot of the hill. There, indeed, stood an old, almost forgotten stepwell, brimming with clear water.

Joy swept through the whole village. Ramu quickly arranged channels to carry the water to his fields. That year, while the crops in neighboring villages were ruined by drought, Ramu's fields stayed lush and green.

Chapter 9: The Truth Revealed

One evening, as Ramu was returning from the fields, he noticed movement near the granary. He hid quietly and watched. For the first time, he saw clearly — a line of rats filing in to carry away the grain he himself had set aside for them, and in return, marking small pebble patterns near the burrow — as though keeping some kind of account.

Everything became clear to Ramu. These were the same rats who had shown him where to dig the well, who had saved him from the snake, and who had led him to the stepwell.

He stepped forward quietly, without startling anyone, placed a bit more grain on the ground, and said, "I don't know if you understand my words or not, but thank you for everything you've done for me. From now on, this home belongs to you too."

Chhotu stood at the mouth of the burrow, watching and listening to it all. He twitched his whiskers, as if to say — "We understand, friend farmer."

Chapter 10: A New Understanding

From that day on, an unusual bond formed between Ramu's farm and the rats' colony. After every harvest, Ramu would set aside grain for the rats in a corner of the granary. In return, the rats kept watch over the field — eating insects to protect the crops, warning of weak spots underground, and raising alarms at the first sign of danger.

Other farmers in the village were astonished that Ramu's field had no trouble from rats, no damage from pests, and always the best harvest.

"Ramu, what's your secret?" Chaudhary asked one day.

Ramu smiled and said, "The secret is simply this — learn to share a little of what you have, whether it's with another person or with the smallest creature on earth. What you give to others comes back around to you."

Chapter 11: The Lesson

The years passed. Mohan and Gita grew up and took over the farming themselves. They too learned the same lesson from their father — that every creature in nature has its purpose, and that far more can be achieved through cooperation than through greed.

Chhotu grew old, and Motu's son became the new young chief, raised from childhood to understand that living alongside the farmer was the colony's true strength.

The story came to be told from generation to generation in the village — "The tale of Ramu the farmer and his friendship with the rats" — teaching that within enmity lies a greater solution: friendship, and that even the smallest creature can become an ally in the greatest of troubles.

THE END

Morals of the Story

1. Greed ultimately brings harm, whether to a rat or to a human.
2. Building trust, rather than fear and enmity, makes relationships stronger.
3. Every creature in nature, big or small, is useful in some way.
4. What we give to others comes back to us in some form.
5. A child's simple, honest thinking (like Gita's) can often show grown-ups a new way forward.